

The Evolving Geopolitical Trajectory of Iran's Presence in Albania

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The relationship between Iran and Albania has undergone significant transformations since the 1980s, marked by a complex interplay of ideological shifts, regional conflicts, and the strategic influence of external powers. Iran's engagement in Albania has involved from initial ideological divergences and subsequent periods of strategic re-engagement to the implementation of soft power initiatives, the pivotal relocation of the Mojahedin-e-Khalq (MEK), and the recent culmination in cyber warfare and diplomatic rupture.

Timeline of Major Events in Iran-Albania Relations (1980s-2024)

Year/Period	Event Description	Key Actors Involved	Significance/Impact on Relations
Early 1980s	Albania's symbolic support for Iranian Revolution; Iran's internal anti-communist purges	Enver Hoxha, Ayatollah Khomeini	Ideological divergence; no diplomatic ties
1992-1995	Iran's military and intelligence support for Bosnian Muslims; Albania as arms transit point	IRGC, Bosnian Muslims, Albania	Strategic re-engagement; Albania's logistical utility
1995	Establishment of Saadi Shirazi Cultural Foundation	Iran, Albanian intellectuals	Soft power expansion begins
Before 2000s	Founding of "The Quran" Foundation (later Shoqata Flladi)	Iran, Albanian imams	Cultural and religious outreach
2005	"The Quran" Foundation replaced by Shoqata Flladi	Iran, Sheikh Vullnet Merja	Shift in soft power approach
2007	Establishment of Rumi Foundation	Iran	Philosophical and later radical ideological outreach
2013	MEK relocation to Albania begins	MEK, U.S., U.N., Albanian Government	Heightened tensions; Albania gains international credit
2016	Largest contingent of MEK members arrives in Albania	MEK, U.N.	Consolidation of MEK presence
2018	Albanian expulsion of Iranian ambassador and another diplomat	Albanian Government, Iran	Diplomatic friction escalates over alleged terrorist plot

2019	Albanian state closes all Iranian cultural organizations	Albanian Government, Iran	End of Iran's official soft power presence in Albania
Jan 2020	Iranian Supreme Leader's remarks against Albania	Ali Khamenei, Edi Rama	Public escalation of diplomatic spat
July 2022	Major Iranian state-sponsored cyberattack on e-Albania	Homeland Justice, Albanian Government	Cyber warfare; disruption of public services
Sep 2022	Albania severs diplomatic ties with Iran	Albanian Government, Iran	Unprecedented diplomatic rupture due to cyberattack
Dec 2023	Iran-linked hackers target Albanian Parliament	Homeland Justice, Albanian Government	Continued cyber aggression
Feb 2024	Iran-backed hackers attack Albania's Institute of Statistics	Homeland Justice, Albanian Government	Persistent cyber conflict
June 2023	Albanian police raid MEK compound Ashraf III	Albanian Police, MEK	Investigation into MEK activities; clashes

I. Early Dynamics and Ideological Divergence (1980s)

The initial phase of Iran-Albania relations in the 1980s was characterized by a superficial alignment rooted in shared anti-Western sentiment. Under the communist rule of Enver Hoxha (1944-1985), Albania was a staunchly isolated Stalinist state, known for its state atheism and prohibition of private property.¹ At this time, Albania maintained close relationship with the Iranian communist movement but no diplomatic relations with the Shah of Iran.³

Hoxha's government expressed support for the Islamic Revolution of Iran and its leader, Ayatollah Khomeini.³ This support was ideologically driven. It was against U.S. imperialism backing the Shah of Iran and influenced by the Iranian Communist Party

(Tudeh Party).¹

The Tudeh Party, while historically significant in Iran, had been banned by the Pahlavi state in 1949 and was subsequently suppressed by the Islamic Republic in 1983.⁴ The support from Tirana was thus a pragmatic, anti-imperialist posture, aligning against a perceived common adversary rather than an embrace of the nascent Islamic Republic's ideology.

During the Iraq-Iran war, the Islamic regime's primary domestic objective changed from uniting the Shah opposition, to combat communist ideology within Iran in order to signal the U.S. and its Arab clients that it was not seeking to side with the Soviet Union.³ This internal struggle culminated in the expulsion, discrediting, and silencing of communist exponents from the Iranian political scene in the early 1980s.³

Consequently, the new regime in Tehran showed no interest in establishing diplomatic or cultural relations with Tirana's communist government.³ Further underscoring this divergence, during the protracted Iran-Iraq War, communist Albania remained committed to the Iranian maoist and communist movement.⁵

II. Strategic Re-engagement During the Bosnian War (Early 1990s)

Following the ideological distance of the 1980s, Iran's presence in the Balkans saw a strategic re-engagement during the Bosnian War (1992-1995). After the dissolution of Yugoslavia, Iran significantly reoriented its political, economic, and military focus towards Bosnia and Herzegovina. This was largely facilitated by the Islamist orientation of the "Mladi Muslimani" group and the close relationship established between Bosnian leader Alija Izetbegovic and Iranian leaders, stemming from his Islamist beliefs and frustration with a perceived lack of Western support.⁶

In its hegemonic efforts to counter Saudi's project of global political Islam, Iran emerged as one of the first Muslim nations to provide substantial support to the Bosnian Muslims (Bosniaks), who are primarily Sunni.⁷

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) played a crucial role, sending over 5,000 tonnes of arms to the Bosnian Muslims. Beyond material aid, the IRGC also supplied trainers and advisors for the Bosnian military and intelligence services, with several dozen Iranian intelligence experts joining the Bosnian Muslim intelligence agency.⁷ Iran, often with the assistance of Turkey, facilitated the smuggling of these arms, frequently routing them through Croatia.⁷ By the war's conclusion, public opinion polls indicated that approximately 86% of the Bosnian Muslim population held

a positive view of Iran.⁷

Albania played a small logistical role during this period, becoming a significant transit point for arms destined for the Bosnian Muslims.⁷ Albania also supplied some of its own ammunition to what its leadership referred to as "friendly states".⁷

Iran sought to expand its intelligence network beyond Bosnia and into the region, but Albania's utility was primarily as a conduit for material support, highlighting its geographical importance in facilitating Iran's broader regional objectives.

This period illustrates Iran's strategic opportunism, leveraging a humanitarian crisis and perceived religious solidarity—despite sectarian differences between the Shia and Sunni—to project influence into Europe.

A notable aspect of this re-engagement was Iran's long-term strategic vision. Even after Western states pressured Bosnian authorities to sever ties and expel Iranian personnel following the war's end in 1995, Iran continued its activities in Bosnia, shifting focus to "culture, education, and upbringing".⁶ This demonstrates that initial military and intelligence engagement during a conflict can lay the groundwork for enduring "soft power" influence, a strategy that can persist even when direct military presence is curtailed. This approach foreshadowed Iran's later attempts to cultivate influence in Albania through similar non-military means.

III. The Era of "Soft Power" and Cultural Diplomacy (Post-1995)

Following the fall of the communist regime in Albania, Iran sought to establish a more formal presence, opening its embassy in Tirana and initiating a series of cultural and educational activities.³ This marked a distinct shift towards a "soft power" approach aimed at fostering cultural ties and extending influence.

Key Iranian cultural and educational initiatives in Albania included:

Name of Foundation/Association	Establishment Date	Stated Aim	Key Activities	Outcome/Impact
Saadi Shirazi Cultural Foundation	1995	"to enliven the Iranian-Albanian cultural ties, make known in Albania the traditions of the Iranian civilization and serve the friendship between these two ancient peoples" ³	Published "Perla" journal; fostered cooperation with Albanian cultural/educational institutions and scholars; published Persian literary works by Albanian poets, often reinterpreting their Ottoman context as Iranian nationalist ³	Limited influence; closed in 2019 ³
"The Quran" Foundation	Before 2000s	Organized Quran teaching courses; published Shiite-perspective Quran exegesis books; opened Kolegji Saadi (high school for girls) ³	Attempted to teach Shiite Islam through extracurriculars at Kolegji Saadi ³	Limited progress; closed in 2005 due to Albanian rejection; replaced by Shoqata Flladi ³
Shoqata Flladi (Breeze)	2005	"the introduction and recognition of the Ahl al-Bayt of the Prophet Muhammad to the Albanian-speaki	Live program on National Radio; published Shiite-content literature (propaganda); cooperated with Albanian sects	Limited influence; leadership (Sheikh Vullnet Merja) known for radical views; closed in 2019 ³

		ng Muslim believers" ³	to introduce Shiite knowledge ³	
Rumi Foundation (Fondacioni Rumi)	2007	Initially, to articulate a philosophical interpretation of Iranian Islam; later shifted to more radical ideological orientation ³	Translated philosophical and mystical works (e.g., Sayed Hossein Nasr); later translated works of extreme Iranian scholars (e.g., Ayatullah Misbah Yazdi) ³	Limited influence; radical shift seen as potentially damaging to democratic values; closed in 2019 ³

Despite these concerted efforts and significant investments, Iran's influence in Albania remained notably limited.³ This was largely attributable to the deeply secular nature of Albanian national identity and the strong U.S. geopolitical influence in the region.³ Observations and studies consistently indicated no obvious influence of Iran or Shi'ism among Albanian citizens, and no discernible Shiite community in the country.³

Efforts to infiltrate the Bektashi community, which is the closest to Shia Islam, failed as the leadership is controlled by the broader national political patronage. This outcome highlights that cultural diplomacy, when perceived as a vehicle for ideological proselytization—particularly Shi'ism in a predominantly Sunni and Bektashi secular context—encounters significant inherent barriers and can be counterproductive if it clashes with deeply entrenched national identities and existing geopolitical alignments. The ultimate failure of this strategy to gain deep traction is evident in its eventual curtailment.

IV. The MEK's Relocation: A Catalyst for Heightened Tensions (2013 Onwards)

A pivotal turning point that led to the cessation of these soft power initiatives was the arrival of the Mojahedin-e-Khalq (MEK) in Albania. The presence of this Iranian opposition group disrupted the "comfort of Iranians in Albania".³ Crucially, the establishment of the MEK in Albania led to an increase in Iranian organization staff in the country, which heightened the sensitivity of official Tirana.³ As a direct consequence of these developments, in 2019, the Albanian state took decisive action,

closing all Iranian cultural organizations operating in Albania and declaring the Iranian ambassador and first secretary undesirable persons.³ Since then, diplomatic relations between Iran and Albania have been maintained at their lowest level, with no official Iranian cultural organizations functioning in Albania.³ The MEK's presence thus acted not merely as a point of contention but as a direct, catalytic factor that prompted Albania to dismantle Iran's entire soft power infrastructure, effectively ending a phase of Iranian influence-building.

The MEK, founded in Iran in 1965, began as an urban guerrilla group opposed to the Shah Mohammad Reza Pahlavi and played a role in the 1979 Iranian Revolution.⁸ However, the group subsequently broke with Ayatollah Khomeini over ideological differences and direction, leading it to go underground in 1981.⁸ Its foundational ideology is characterized as a "combination of Islam and Marxism" ⁸ or "Marxist-Islamist".⁹

Notably, the U.S. State Department and the U.N. Refugee Agency (UNHCR) have identified the MEK as possessing "cult-like characteristics," including a personality cult centered around its leader Maryam Rajavi, a mandatory vow of eternal divorce, and the separation of children from their parents.⁹ The MEK was responsible for various attacks against the Islamic Republic, including a 1981 bombing that resulted in the deaths of high-ranking officials.⁸ Its leaders eventually fled to Iraq in 1986, where the group notably aided Saddam Hussein during the Iran-Iraq War, a decision that rendered them "deeply unpopular" within Iran.⁸ While initially designated as a foreign terrorist organization by the U.S. and EU, the MEK was later delisted after committing to renounce weapons and violent tactics.⁹ They continued however their subversive activities from Albania, mainly in the digital space, such as attacks on Iranian digital infrastructure and misinformation.

The relocation of the MEK to Albania was a complex operation, facilitated by an agreement between the U.S. administration and the Albanian government in 2013, with management oversight from the UNHCR.¹³ The U.S. actively sought refuge for MEK members from various governments, and Albania was the sole nation to respond positively.¹³ This initiative was supported by a \$20 million donation from the U.S. to the UNHCR for resettlement efforts, alongside security and economic development assistance provided to Albania.¹⁴ Albania initially accepted around 200 MEK members between 2013 and 2014, with the largest contingent of approximately 1,900 arriving in 2016.¹³ The MEK subsequently established its new headquarters, Ashraf III, a highly fortified camp located near Durrës in Manëz.¹²

Albania's decision to host the MEK was strategically motivated, driven by gratitude for

U.S. support during the Kosovo War and the desire for U.S. advocacy for Albania's NATO and EU membership bids.¹³ This move undeniably garnered Albania significant international credit, particularly from the United States.

This situation illustrates how the MEK, despite its controversial history and "cult-like" characteristics, became a geopolitical instrument leveraged by the U.S. and accepted by Albania within the broader U.S.-Iran rivalry. While Albania gained immediate diplomatic advantages, it simultaneously incurred the long-term burden and security risks associated with hosting a highly contentious opposition group, effectively positioning itself as a direct target for Iranian retaliation and a battleground for information warfare. Although MEK members were ostensibly considered refugees under international law, reports from defectors suggest they were held as "hostages" within the headquarters, lacking economic and social rights and remaining entirely dependent on the group's leadership.¹⁴

The presence of the MEK in Albania immediately escalated diplomatic friction and ignited a persistent propaganda war between Iran and the MEK. Iran views the MEK's presence as a significant challenge and has initiated aggressive propaganda campaigns against the group.¹⁰ The MEK, in turn, has countered these attacks with its own narratives, frequently bolstered by support from U.S. officials.¹³ Investigations have exposed MEK "troll farms" operating from Ashraf III, where "online soldiers" are reportedly trained to disseminate hashtags advocating for the overthrow of the Iranian regime.⁵ Evidence of these activities emerged when Facebook removed hundreds of fake accounts linked to a MEK troll farm in Albania.⁵ Iran has also sought to influence the narrative by targeting individuals sympathetic to its regime or opposed to the MEK, offering all-expenses-paid trips to Tehran for critical journalists and reposting articles through anonymous pro-Iranian accounts.¹⁰

This escalating tension culminated in several diplomatic expulsions. In December 2018, Albania accused Iran of plotting terrorist attacks within the country, specifically during the FIFA World Cup qualification, leading to the expulsion of the Iranian ambassador and another diplomat.⁵ Iran, in response, dismissed these accusations as fabrications orchestrated under American and Israeli pressure.⁵ The diplomatic spat intensified in January 2020 when Iranian Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and President Hassan Rouhani delivered speeches implicitly criticizing Albania as "a small and sinister country" for hosting the MEK. This prompted a strong condemnation from Albanian Prime Minister Edi Rama, who publicly endorsed the U.S. attack against Iran.⁵ While Albania initially attempted to maintain an ambiguous relationship, supporting the MEK while also seeking cordial relations with Iran, this stance became increasingly untenable. The ongoing digital conflict, evidenced by MEK "troll farms" and Iranian

counter-propaganda, illustrates a critical evolution in geopolitical conflict, where information warfare and cyber operations have become a primary battleground. Albania, by hosting the MEK, became an unwitting frontline in this asymmetric digital conflict, exposing its digital infrastructure and public discourse to continuous manipulation and attacks. This highlights the increasing importance of cybersecurity and information resilience in modern statecraft, even for smaller nations caught in larger geopolitical struggles.

V. Cyber Warfare and Diplomatic Severance (2022-2023)

The protracted tensions between Iran and Albania, exacerbated by the MEK's presence, escalated into direct cyber warfare, culminating in a series of Iranian state-sponsored cyberattacks against Albanian government infrastructure. These attacks were primarily attributed to Iranian state-backed hacker groups, most notably "Homeland Justice," which has documented links to Iran's Revolutionary Guard and Ministry of Intelligence and Security.¹⁵

A significant cyberattack occurred in July 2022, when Homeland Justice launched a coordinated assault that crippled Albania's digital government portal, e-Albania, disrupting essential public services ranging from school enrollment to property registration.¹⁵ An FBI investigation later revealed that Iranian state cyber actors had maintained continuous network access to the Albanian government's systems for approximately 14 months prior to this attack, periodically exfiltrating email content.¹⁸ This was followed by another substantial attack in September 2022, targeting the Total Information Management System (TIMS) of the state police, which manages data for individuals entering and exiting Albania. This breach led to data exfiltration and the temporary suspension of the system, causing significant border queues.¹⁸ Subsequent attacks included a December 2023 incident targeting the Albanian Parliament, which temporarily halted its operations¹², and an attack in February 2024 against the country's Institute of Statistics.⁵ These attacks were explicitly linked by the "Homeland Justice" group to Albania's continued hosting of the MEK, with the hackers accusing Albania of sheltering "terrorists".¹²

Albania's response to these cyber aggressions was decisive and unprecedented. Citing "undeniable evidence" of Iran's responsibility for the July 2022 attack, Albanian Prime Minister Edi Rama announced on September 7, 2022, the severance of

diplomatic relations with Iran.⁵ All Iranian embassy staff in Tirana were ordered to depart Albania within 24 hours.⁵ This action marked a significant precedent in international relations, as it was notably the first instance globally where diplomatic ties were severed as a direct consequence of a cyberattack.¹⁵ The U.S., Microsoft, and cybersecurity firm Mandiant corroborated the attribution of the July 2022 attack to Iranian state-backed actors, with the U.S. subsequently imposing sanctions on Iran's Ministry of Intelligence.¹⁵ This establishes that cyber operations are now considered acts of aggression warranting severe diplomatic repercussions, akin to traditional military or intelligence actions, implying a new and evolving understanding of sovereignty and state-sponsored attacks in the digital domain.

Further demonstrating its firm stance, in June 2023, Albanian police raided the MEK compound, Ashraf III, acting on orders from the Special Court Against Corruption and Organized Crime. The raid was prompted by suspicions of terrorist and cybercrime activities being conducted from within the compound.¹⁰ The operation resulted in clashes, one fatality, and over 100 injuries.¹⁰ While Iran has consistently denied the existence of a MEK troll farm⁵ and accused Albania of fabricating claims under U.S. and Israeli pressure⁵, the police raid on the MEK compound is highly significant. It indicates that Albania is not entirely passive or uncritical of the MEK's activities, even while hosting them under U.S. auspices. This implies a complex and potentially precarious balancing act for Albania, caught between its alliance with the U.S. and the severe retaliatory actions from Iran. The persistent cyberattacks, explicitly linked to Albania's hosting of the MEK, underscore that the MEK's presence remains a continuous source of geopolitical tension, highlighting the inherent risks for smaller nations that become proxy battlegrounds for larger geopolitical rivalries, forcing them to manage internal security concerns alongside external pressures. Despite these cyberattacks and disinformation campaigns, Iran's influence within Albania itself continues to be limited due to Albania's firm Western alignment.¹⁰

Conclusion: The Enduring Complexity of Iran-Albania Relations

The relationship between Iran and Albania has undergone a profound transformation over the past four decades, shifting from initial ideological distance to a state of overt diplomatic hostility. What began as a largely symbolic Albanian support for the Iranian Revolution in the 1980s, driven by a shared anti-Western stance rather than genuine ideological alignment, quickly dissipated as the new Islamic Republic prioritized the

suppression of communist movements internally. This early period was characterized by minimal direct engagement, largely due to Iran's internal focus and Albania's self-imposed isolation.

The early 1990s saw a brief, opportunistic re-engagement during the Bosnian War, where Albania served as a logistical transit point for Iranian military aid to Bosnian Muslims. This period demonstrated Iran's strategic intent to project influence into the Balkans, laying groundwork for future non-military engagement. Following the conflict, Iran transitioned to a "soft power" strategy in Albania, establishing cultural and educational foundations like Saadi Shirazi and Shogata Flladi. However, these initiatives ultimately yielded limited influence, encountering resistance from Albania's secular national identity and strong Western alignment, leading to their eventual closure in 2019.

The pivotal turning point, fundamentally altering the bilateral dynamic, was the relocation of the Mojahedin-e-Khalq (MEK) to Albania starting in 2013. This move, facilitated by the U.S. and U.N., positioned Albania as a strategic host for an Iranian opposition group, directly drawing Tirana into the long-standing Iran-MEK conflict. While Albania gained international credit, it concurrently became a direct arena for Iranian retaliation, manifesting in an escalating propaganda war and, critically, a series of state-sponsored cyberattacks.

The culmination of these tensions in 2022-2023, marked by debilitating Iranian cyberattacks on Albanian government infrastructure, led to Albania's unprecedented decision to sever diplomatic ties. This act set a significant precedent in international relations, signaling that cyber aggression is now considered a legitimate *casus belli* for severe diplomatic repercussions. The Albanian police raid on the MEK compound in 2023 further underscores the complex and precarious balancing act Albania faces, caught between its Western alliances and the persistent security threats emanating from its role as a host for a highly contentious opposition group.

In conclusion, the presence of the MEK has become the defining factor in Iran-Albania relations, transforming Albania into a proxy battleground in the broader Iran-Western rivalry. The relationship remains fraught with tension, characterized by a low level of diplomatic engagement and the enduring threat of cyber warfare, indicating a continued state of geopolitical friction for the foreseeable future.

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